Insights and Recommendations for Concrete Strength and Mix Planning

Abby Zhang, Emily Shi

Executive Summary

This report helps a ready-mix producer meet specified strength while controlling cement use, water additions, and curing schedules. It screens formulations before committing materials and laboratory capacity. The analysis uses 1,030 concrete tests: 900 for model development and 130 for evaluation.

The principal formulation finding is that water demand must be balanced against strength: holding other recorded inputs fixed, the basic model associates 10 kg/m³ more cement with **1.32 MPa higher strength**, and 10 kg/m³ more water with **1.34 MPa lower strength**. Higher water-to-binder ratios are associated with lower strength, while mixes containing more superplasticizer generally use less water. Together with the positive age effect, these findings support evaluating binder composition, water control, and admixture dosage as a complete formulation at the required delivery or acceptance age.

The recommended prediction model explains approximately **75.7% of the strength differences in the held-out samples**, compared with 36.8% for the basic linear model. Its root mean squared error (RMSE), an overall measure of prediction error, is about **7.4 MPa**, which is substantial when a mix is close to a customer's strength requirement. This is a planning aid for comparing candidates, not a substitute for strength testing or an assurance that every batch will meet specification.

- **Control water additions:** review workability and water demand together rather than treating added water as a harmless adjustment.
- **Compare binder options:** evaluate cement, slag, and fly ash together before increasing cement content.
- **Verify before deployment:** test shortlisted mixes locally and retain laboratory-based release decisions.

Problem Context & Data Overview

For the producer, better mix screening could reduce unsuccessful trial batches and identify where extra cement may provide limited benefit. Reliable strength estimates could also support discussions about curing time and production scheduling. However, the dataset contains no material prices, delivery costs, or acceptance specifications, so this analysis cannot establish the cheapest compliant recipe or quantify financial savings.

Cement reacts with water to form the binding paste that holds concrete together. Slag and fly ash are supplementary binding materials that can replace part of the cement and influence strength development over time. Coarse aggregate provides the larger stone structure, while fine aggregate fills smaller spaces and influences packing and water demand. Superplasticizer improves flow with less reliance on added water, and curing

age records the time available for strength development; these roles are consistent with American Cement Association guidance.

Table 1 summarizes the 900 training observations; evaluation samples remain separate. Quantities are in kilograms per cubic meter, age in days, and strength in megapascals. The varied formulations and ages mean that average strength is not a 28-day performance target.

Measure	Unit	Mean	SD	Minimum	Maximum
Cement	kg/m³	277.87	106.00	102.00	540.0
Blast furnace slag	kg/m³	76.11	84.07	0.00	305.3
Fly ash	kg/m³	57.38	64.26	0.00	200.1
Water	kg/m³	180.72	22.28	121.75	247.0
Superplasticizer	kg/m³	6.86	5.98	0.00	32.2
Coarse aggregate	kg/m³	973.76	77.57	801.00	1145.0
Fine aggregate	kg/m³	772.33	81.91	594.00	992.6
Age	days	46.04	61.32	1.00	365.0
Compressive strength	MPa	36.93	16.65	2.33	82.6

Table 1: Training-data summary (900 observations; SD is sample standard deviation).

Figure 1 shows how strength varies with cement content and curing age in the training data. Higher cement quantities and longer curing times are generally associated with greater strength, but observations with similar values still differ considerably. That spread shows why one ingredient or age alone cannot reliably determine the performance of a complete mix.

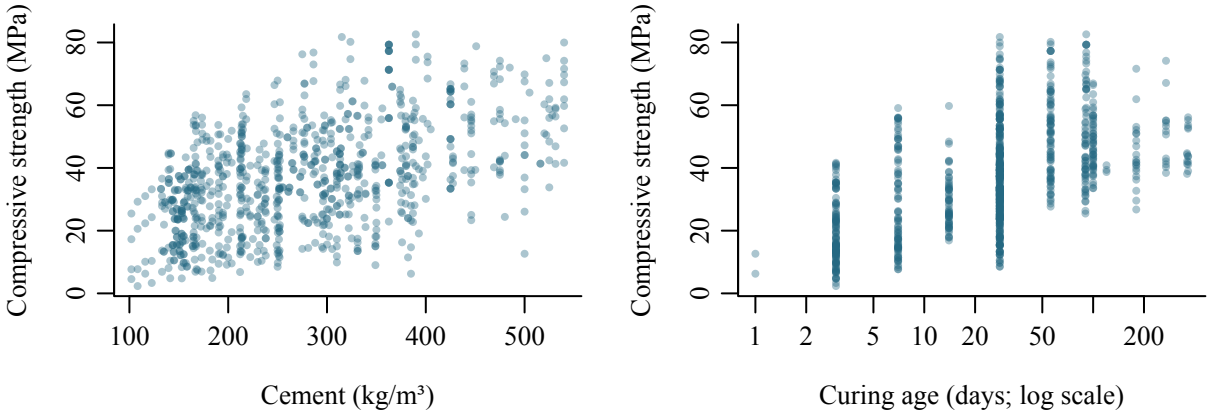


Figure 1: Cement content and curing age versus strength in the 900 training observations; each dot represents one observation, and the age axis is logarithmic to distinguish early curing times.

Model Reliability & Analytical Findings

Table 2 compares the basic model with the recommended model, which uses logarithmic features to represent diminishing changes in strength as ingredient quantities or age increase. Rescaling the inputs does not change the basic model's best predictions, so the raw and standardized versions share one row. The recom-

mended model explains about 79.8% of strength differences during development and 75.7% in the held-out group, suggesting useful transfer to these unseen observations. One fixed evaluation group cannot establish reliability across all plants or future seasons.

Model	Training R^2	Testing R^2	Testing RMSE (MPa)
Basic / standardized	0.624	0.368	11.89
Log-transformed	0.798	0.757	7.37

Table 2: Model reliability: R^2 measures the share of strength variation explained; RMSE summarizes prediction error in MPa (900 training / 130 testing observations).

The basic model's coefficients describe ingredient associations with other inputs fixed. The cement and water effects above support reviewing water demand alongside binder content. Actual recipe changes must also preserve volume, workability, and feasible proportions.

The recommended model gives a more flexible illustration: increasing cement from 250 to 275 kg/m³ corresponds to about **2.24 MPa** higher predicted strength, holding other recorded inputs fixed. Increasing age from seven to 28 days corresponds to about **11.6 MPa**, with the same qualifications. These examples support evaluating strength at the customer's required age instead of assuming the same benefit from every additional curing day.

Water and binder balance. Water enables hydration and improves handling, but excess water can increase pore space and reduce strength, creating a strength-workability trade-off. The water-to-cement ratio is water mass divided by cement mass: 150 kg/m³ of water with 300 kg/m³ of cement gives 0.50, whereas 180 kg/m³ gives 0.60. That 30 kg/m³ water increase corresponds to about **4.02 MPa lower predicted strength** in the basic model, holding all other inputs fixed. Across the training observations, water-to-cement and water-to-binder ratios correlate negatively with strength (**r = -0.52 and -0.63**, respectively), where binder includes cement, slag, and fly ash; these are descriptive associations, not estimated causal effects.

Superplasticizer and workability. Superplasticizer content and water content have a negative correlation (**r = -0.66**), consistent with using admixture to maintain flow while limiting water. The basic model estimates only **0.12 MPa** per additional kg/m³ after accounting for other inputs, with considerable uncertainty; the log model estimates about **0.29 MPa** for an increase from 5 to 6 kg/m³. This model dependence cautions against treating dosage alone as a reliable strength lever. For procurement and production decisions, compare approved water-and-admixture combinations through paired trials that measure both strength and workability, because workability itself is absent from this dataset.

Binder composition and curing. Slag and fly ash should be assessed alongside cement and test age: their apparent effects can reflect changes elsewhere in the formulation. For example, fly ash has a negative association in a one-predictor fit but a positive coefficient in the basic multivariable model, illustrating why isolated comparisons can mislead. These additive models contain no explicit water-by-cement or admixture-by-water

interaction terms, so the findings identify coupled physical decisions without quantifying interaction effects. No optimum water ratio, binder replacement percentage, or admixture dosage has been established.

Strategic Recommendations & Implementation Plan

The following rules support a controlled pilot. Production, quality control, and purchasing should agree on products and responsibilities before implementation. Each proposed change requires measured-strength verification.

1. **Review every proposed water increase.** Record the requested addition and compare the predicted strength before approving a trial, keeping the intended test age fixed. Where flow is the concern, evaluate an approved superplasticizer adjustment in a paired laboratory trial rather than automatically increasing water. Maintain the existing approved recipe until strength and workability checks support a change.

2. **Screen binder alternatives before adding cement.** For each pilot product, compare its current mix with two feasible alternatives that adjust cement and supplementary materials within locally approved limits. Rank candidates using predicted strength and current material quotations, then test the most promising options at the required age. Do not claim cost savings or select a replacement percentage from this dataset alone.

3. **Evaluate schedules at the required strength age.** Compare candidate predictions at seven and 28 days when those ages match the product's testing plan. Use the results to prioritize tests and identify mixes likely to need longer curing. Authorize earlier handling or release only through the producer's established measured-strength procedures.

4. **Keep initial deployment within familiar conditions.** Flag any ingredient quantity or age outside Table 1's observed range for engineering review, and also review unusual combinations inside those ranges. Begin with one established product family and record every prediction alongside its laboratory result. Expand only after the quality team confirms acceptable errors for that product and its contractual requirements.

During the first month, record batch quantities, test age, predicted and measured strength, material source, and curing conditions. Review errors weekly and investigate repeated overprediction before further changes. Set product-specific alerts from local errors and customer requirements; the 7.4 MPa error measure is a reference, not a safety allowance.

Review strength failures, systematic overprediction, and error size monthly, reassessing after supplier or process changes. Aggregate properties, moisture, temperature, and curing practices may affect performance beyond these recorded inputs. Evaluate updated models on separate new batches, retain dated approval records, and keep final quality assurance grounded in local testing.